

Front desk operations: documentation set

Northwind Inn, 40 rooms, illustrative · Document set FD, issue 1 · prepared 8 September 2026 by Joshua Matalon as a sample of the format

Six documents on four levels: one policy that says what the front desk is for, three procedures that say who does what and in what order, one work instruction that says exactly how one task is done, and the forms and register that prove it happened. Each document has an owner, a version and a review date. Nothing here is a template with blanks; every step was written for this operation and can be changed in one place.

DOCUMENT REGISTER

ID	Title	Level	Owner	Version	Effective	Review by
FD-POL-01	Front desk policy	1 Policy	General manager	1.0	15 Sep 2026	15 Sep 2027
FD-P-01	Guest check-in	2 Procedure	Front office manager	1.0	15 Sep 2026	15 Sep 2027
FD-P-02	Check-out and settlement	2 Procedure	Front office manager	1.0	15 Sep 2026	15 Sep 2027
FD-P-03	Incidents and complaints	2 Procedure	General manager	1.0	15 Sep 2026	15 Sep 2027
FD-WI-01	Reissuing a room key card	3 Work instruction	Front office manager	1.0	15 Sep 2026	15 Sep 2027
FD-F-01	Shift checklist	4 Form	Shift lead	1.0	15 Sep 2026	15 Sep 2027
FD-R-01	Incident register	4 Record	General manager	1.0	15 Sep 2026	15 Sep 2027

Levels follow the four-tier structure used in ISO 9001 quality systems: policy, procedures, work instructions, records. A change to a procedure changes its version; a change to a form changes only the form. Superseded versions are kept for two years.

HOW THE SET IS USED

- **New staff** read the policy and the three procedures in their first shift, then work the shift checklist under a lead for three shifts.
- **Every shift** completes FD-F-01. The lead signs it. The general manager reviews the week's checklists on Monday.
- **Every incident** is entered in FD-R-01 within the shift, following FD-P-03. The register is the only place incidents live.
- **Review:** each document is re-read by its owner at the review date, or sooner if the register shows the same failure three times.

Front desk policy

Document	FD-POL-01 · Level 1 · Version 1.0 · Effective 15 Sep 2026
Owner	General manager
Applies to	Everyone who works a front desk shift, including cover staff

PURPOSE

The front desk is the only part of the hotel every guest deals with in person, at the two moments that fix their opinion of the stay: arrival and departure. This policy sets what every guest can expect from those moments and what every staff member is accountable for.

COMMITMENTS

- A guest with a reservation is checked in within five minutes of reaching the desk, and is never asked for information the reservation already holds.
- A guest's folio is correct at check-out. Any charge the guest questions is explained from the record, and removed if it cannot be.
- Every complaint is written down, answered by a named person, and closed with the guest told what happened.
- No guest is given a key to a room without proof of identity that matches the reservation.
- Guest data is used only to deliver the stay and is not written anywhere outside the property management system.

RESPONSIBILITIES

Role	Accountable for
General manager	This policy; incident review; approval of any refund above \$100; the incident register.
Front office manager	The procedures and work instructions; training and sign-off of new staff; weekly checklist review.
Shift lead	The shift checklist; float and key inventory at handover; first response to any incident.
Front desk agent	Following the procedures as written; recording every incident and complaint; raising anything the procedures do not cover.

MEASURES

Measure	Target	Source	Reviewed
Check-in time, reservation to key	Under 5 minutes for 95 percent of arrivals	Property management system timestamps	Weekly
Folio disputes at check-out	Under 2 percent of departures	FD-R-01, category "billing"	Weekly
Complaints closed within 24 hours	100 percent	FD-R-01, closed date	Weekly
Shift checklists completed and signed	100 percent	FD-F-01	Weekly

Guest check-in

Document	FD-P-01 · Level 2 · Version 1.0 · Effective 15 Sep 2026
Owner	Front office manager
Records	Reservation record in the property management system; FD-F-01 for arrivals count

PURPOSE AND SCOPE

Getting an arriving guest from the desk to the right room with the right key, correctly billed, in under five minutes. Covers reserved and walk-in arrivals from 3 pm. Early arrivals follow the same steps after room readiness is confirmed with housekeeping.

RESPONSIBILITIES

The front desk agent performs every step. The shift lead is called for any step marked **lead**. The front office manager decides any exception this procedure does not cover.

PROCEDURE

1. Greet the guest and ask for the surname on the reservation. Open the reservation before asking anything else.
2. Confirm the stay from the record, not from the guest: dates, room type, rate, number of guests. Read them back once.
3. Ask for photo identification. The name must match the reservation. If it does not, and the guest is not listed as an additional occupant, call the **lead**; do not issue a key.
4. Take a payment card for incidentals and pre-authorise the amount set in the rate plan. Tell the guest the amount and that it is a hold, not a charge.
5. Assign the room from the ready list only. A room marked dirty or inspected-failed is never assigned, whatever the guest was promised.
6. Encode two key cards and test one on the encoder's reader. A card that fails the reader is destroyed, not handed over.
7. Tell the guest the room number by writing it on the key sleeve, not aloud. State breakfast hours, Wi-Fi name and check-out time.
8. Mark the reservation checked in. The timestamp on this step is the check-in time measured against the five-minute target.

EXCEPTIONS

Situation	Action	Who decides
No reservation found under any spelling	Search by phone number and arrival date; if still absent, offer walk-in rate for an available room	Agent, lead if rate is questioned
Payment card declined	Ask for another card; cash deposit accepted at the rate plan amount with a receipt from FD-F-01	Lead
Room type sold out on arrival	Upgrade at no charge to the next type; note the reason on the reservation	Lead
Guest under 18 alone	Not checked in without a parent or guardian present	General manager

Check-out and settlement

Document	FD-P-02 · Level 2 · Version 1.0 · Effective 15 Sep 2026
Owner	Front office manager
Records	Folio and payment record in the property management system; FD-R-01 for any dispute

PURPOSE AND SCOPE

Closing a stay with a folio the guest agrees with and a payment that matches it. Covers desk check-out, express check-out by drop box, and settlement of a stay that ended without the guest presenting.

PROCEDURE

1. Open the folio by room number and confirm the surname. Ask whether anything was used from the room this morning that is not yet posted.
2. Print or show the itemised folio. Read the total aloud; do not read every line unless asked.
3. If the guest questions a charge, find it in the record. A charge with no supporting entry is removed on the spot and logged in FD-R-01 as "billing". A charge with a supporting entry is explained; if the guest still disputes it, call the **lead**.
4. Settle to the card on file unless the guest offers another method. Release the pre-authorisation hold and say so.
5. Collect key cards. Uncollected cards are deactivated by marking the room departed, which happens in the next step.
6. Mark the room departed. This notifies housekeeping and deactivates the keys.
7. Offer the receipt by email or print. Email is the default; ask, do not assume.

EXPRESS AND UNATTENDED CHECK - OUT

Cards found in the drop box are matched to rooms with departure today and processed with steps 4 to 7, with the receipt emailed. A room past check-out time with no cards returned is called once; if unanswered, the room is marked departed at 1 pm and settled to the card on file, and a note is left on the folio.

REFUNDS

Amount	Approval	Recorded in
Up to \$100	Shift lead	Folio note and FD-R-01
Over \$100	General manager, same day	Folio note and FD-R-01, with the manager's initials

Incidents and complaints

Document	FD-P-03 · Level 2 · Version 1.0 · Effective 15 Sep 2026
Owner	General manager
Records	FD-R-01 incident register

PURPOSE AND SCOPE

Every complaint, injury, damage, safety event and billing dispute is recorded in one place, answered by a named person, and closed with the guest informed. Covers anything a guest raises and anything staff observe that affects a guest or the property.

PROCEDURE

1. Make the guest safe first. A medical or fire event is called to emergency services before anything is written.
2. Listen without interrupting, then repeat the complaint back in one sentence and ask if that is right.
3. Enter the incident in FD-R-01 during the same shift: date, time, room, category, what happened in the guest's words, immediate action taken, and your name.
4. Resolve what is within your authority: a room move, a comped item up to \$25, a maintenance call. Record the resolution.
5. Anything beyond that goes to the **lead** now, not at handover. The lead's decision and name are added to the entry.
6. Tell the guest what was done, or when they will hear, before they leave the desk.
7. Close the entry when the guest has been told the outcome. The close date is what the 24-hour measure uses.

CATEGORIES

Category	Examples	Escalate to
Room	Cleanliness, noise, amenity missing, temperature	Lead if a move is needed
Billing	Disputed charge, wrong rate, refund	Lead; general manager above \$100
Safety	Injury, fire alarm, security concern, hazard	General manager, same day, always
Service	Staff conduct, waiting time, promise not kept	Front office manager
Property	Damage by or to a guest, lost property	Lead

The register is reviewed every Monday. Three entries in the same category with the same cause in a month trigger a review of the procedure that should have prevented it.

Reissuing a room key card

Document

FD-WI-01 · Level 3 · Version 1.0 · Effective 15 Sep 2026

Owner

Front office manager

Used by

Front desk agents; part of FD-P-01 step 6 when a card is lost or fails

WHEN THIS APPLIES

A guest reports a lost card, a card stops opening the door, or a card is found and returned. The risk this instruction controls is issuing a working key to someone who is not the registered guest.

INSTRUCTION

1. Ask for the room number and the surname. Open the reservation. Do not say the room number back; the guest tells you.
 2. Ask for photo identification and match the name to the reservation or its listed occupants. No match: call the lead; do not proceed.
 3. In the key system, choose **Replace**, not **Duplicate**. Replace cancels every card issued for the room; Duplicate leaves a lost card live.
 4. Encode one card. Test it on the encoder's reader. If it fails, destroy it and encode another.
 5. Hand the card over in a sleeve with the room number written on it. Tell the guest that any earlier card no longer works.
 6. Note "key replaced" with the time on the reservation. If the card was reported lost outside the guest's own control, also enter it in FD-R-01 under "property".
-

CHECK

The reservation shows one "key replaced" note per reissue, and the key system shows exactly one active card set for the room. A second active set means Duplicate was used; correct it with Replace and record the correction.

Shift checklist

Document FD-F-01 · Level 4 · Version 1.0 · Effective 15 Sep 2026
Completed by The agent on shift; signed by the shift lead at handover
Kept Binder at the desk for the month, then the general manager's file for two years

Date	Shift	Agent	Lead
------	-------	-------	------

Morning / evening / night

START OF SHIFT

- ☐ Float counted and agrees with the handover sheet. Amount: _____
- ☐ Blank key cards counted. Count: _____
- ☐ Arrivals list printed; rooms for VIP or accessible bookings confirmed ready with housekeeping
- ☐ Open items in FD-R-01 from the previous shift read

DURING SHIFT

- ☐ Every arrival checked in per FD-P-01. Arrivals: _____ Over five minutes: _____
- ☐ Every departure settled per FD-P-02. Departures: _____ Disputes logged: _____
- ☐ Incidents entered in FD-R-01 during the shift, not after. Entries: _____
- ☐ Housekeeping status board reconciled with the system at 2 pm (morning) or 8 pm (evening)

END OF SHIFT

- ☐ Float counted and recorded on the handover sheet. Amount: _____
- ☐ Key cards counted. Count: _____ Difference from start explained: _____
- ☐ Open incidents handed over by name to the incoming agent
- ☐ This checklist signed by the lead

Agent signature

Lead signature

Time of handover

Incident register

Document	FD-R-01 · Level 4 · Version 1.0 · Effective 15 Sep 2026
Kept in	The shared workbook FD-R-01.xlsx, one row per incident, never deleted; a closed row is a closed incident
Reviewed	Every Monday by the general manager; summary counts by category go into the weekly measures

COLUMNS

Column	Content	Entered by
Ref	Year and running number, 2026-041	Automatic
Date, time	When it happened, not when it was written	Agent
Room	Room number, or "public area" with location	Agent
Category	Room, billing, safety, service, property (FD-P-03)	Agent
What happened	In the guest's words where there is a guest; facts, not judgements	Agent
Immediate action	What was done at the desk, with any amount comped	Agent
Escalated to	Name and time, if escalated	Agent
Decision	What the lead or manager decided	Lead or manager
Guest informed	Date and by whom	Whoever told them
Closed	Date; blank means open	Whoever closed it

EXAMPLE ENTRIES

Ref	Date, time	Room	Category	What happened	Immediate action	Closed
2026-041	6 Sep, 21:40	214	Room	"The air conditioning makes a grinding noise and I can't sleep."	Moved to 306, same rate; maintenance ticket raised	7 Sep
2026-042	7 Sep, 07:55	118	Billing	Guest questioned a \$14 minibar charge; no restock record found	Charge removed at check-out	7 Sep
2026-043	7 Sep, 16:10	Lobby	Safety	Wet floor near entrance after rain, guest slipped, no injury	Mat and sign placed; escalated to general manager 16:20	

Entries above are illustrative. The register lives in the workbook; this page defines it.